

The Fokker Spin 3
taking off in 1911

Great Manufacturers Fokker

Although the name “Fokker” is often linked with German fighter planes, Anthony Fokker was actually a Dutch national who later became an American citizen. The company he founded produced some ground-breaking civil and military machines, and during the 1920s it became the largest manufacturer of aircraft in the world.

BORN IN THE DUTCH EAST INDIES (now Indonesia) in 1890, Anthony Fokker returned to the Netherlands at the age of four because his father wanted his children to receive a Dutch upbringing. Like many of the early aviation pioneers, Fokker was not a studious boy. He did not complete his higher education, preferring engineering and practical mechanics to schoolwork.



Anthony Fokker
(1890-1939)

Fokker was sent to Germany by his father in 1910 to train as an automobile mechanic but, having been inspired by Wilbur Wright's demonstration flights

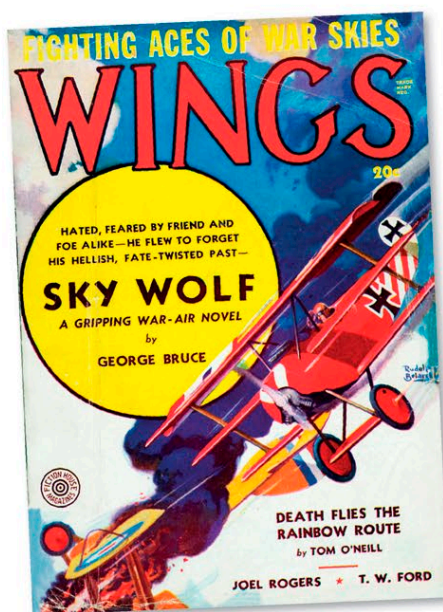
in France in 1908, he instead began work on his first aircraft, called the Spin (Dutch for “spider”). Fokker soon gained recognition for his aeronautical aptitude, both as a designer and a pilot, and in 1912 he founded his first company, Fokker Aeroplanbau. He built several aircraft before relocating the factory to Schwerin and renaming the company Fokker Flugzeugwerke GmbH. When World War I started, the German government took control of the factory, although Fokker was retained as director and designer.

In 1915 Fokker demonstrated his Eindecker fighter, with its revolutionary armament. Although Fokker did not invent the concept of firing a machine gun through the propeller disk, his company did design the synchronization system that made it possible. This system, called an “interrupter gear,” revolutionized aerial combat, with the so-called “Fokker Scourge” of 1915 decimating the British and French air corps. During the war Fokker also built the Fokker DrI triplane and the very advanced Fokker DVII, launched in 1918. It was in a DrI that the top-scoring ace of the war, Rittmeister Manfred von Richthofen—the “Red Baron”—met his death. The DVII is unique in being the only machine to be specifically mentioned in an armistice agreement—in the Treaty of Versailles the victorious allies insisted that all DVIIs be handed over.

“Mystery surrounded the Fokker. Few... attacked by it had come back to tell the tale.”

CECIL ARTHUR LEWIS (1898-1997), BRITISH FIGHTER PILOT

After the war Fokker owed a small fortune in taxes to the German exchequer, so he returned to the Netherlands with six trains full of parts and around 180 aircraft. This allowed him to restart production very quickly, and the company was soon delivering aircraft to several different air forces. In 1923 Fokker relocated to the United States, and set up an American division called the Atlantic Aircraft Corporation, quickly renamed the Fokker Aircraft Corporation. The company soon began to dominate the civil aircraft market. Its FVIIa/3m trimotor was particularly successful, capturing 40 percent of the US market by 1936, and ultimately being operated by 54 different airlines. The FVIIa/3m's first real competitor was the Ford Trimotor, which copied many of the Fokker's features. A Fokker Trimotor won the 1925 Ford Reliability Tour, and the type was used by famous aviators, such as Richard E. Byrd and Charles Kingsford Smith, on many pioneering and record-breaking flights.



Air stories

The 1938 American pulp fiction magazine *Wings* featured stories of the world-famous Fokker triplane in action during World War I, the first conflict to involve air warfare.

